1517 – 1689

CROWN, CHURCH, OR PARLIAMENT

Reformation, Royal Supremacy, Civil War & The Bill of Rights



Primary Portrait (c. 1588): The Armada Portrait of Elizabeth I, symbolising sovereign statehood, Protestant survival, and English naval defiance.

HISTORICAL ENQUIRY • UNIT NARRATIVE SYNOPSIS 1517 – 1689

"From the spark of the Protestant Reformation and Henry VIII's Break with Rome to the execution of Charles I and the 1689 Bill of Rights, explore how 170 years of religious conflict, civil war, and constitutional struggle transformed Britain from an absolute monarchy into a parliamentary state."

THE CANONICAL ENQUIRIES • SCHEME OF LEARNING DIRECTORY **A3 SADDLE-STITCH FORMAT**

Enquiry 01	**The Reformation & The Break with Rome**	*Why did Henry VIII break with Rome, and how was Royal Supremacy established?*	**Page 3**
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CORE CONCEPTS Reformation • Royal Supremacy • Act of Supremacy • Via Media • Recusancy • Spanish Armada • Divine Right of Kings • Eleven Years' Tyranny • Regicide • Restoration • Bill of Rights 1689

Chronological Turning Points Highway (1517–1689)

Twelve Decisive Causal Turning Points That Transformed the British State

31 Oct 1517

Martin Luther Sparks the Protestant Reformation Ref [1.1]

German monk Martin Luther nails his 95 Theses in Wittenberg, challenging papal corruption and indulgence sales across Catholic Europe.

1527–1529

Henry VIII's "Great Matter" & Roman Deadlock Ref [1.2–1.3]

Desperate for a male Tudor heir, Henry demands an annulment from Catherine of Aragon. Pope Clement VII, captive to Charles V, refuses.

1534–1540

Act of Supremacy & Dissolution of the Monasteries Ref [1.4–1.6]

Parliament declares Henry the Supreme Head of the Church of England. Thomas Cromwell dissolves 800 monasteries, seizing colossal wealth.

1547–1558

The Tudor Religious Rollercoaster (Edward & Mary) Ref [2.1]

Radical Protestant reform under Edward VI is violently reversed by Mary I, who burns 284 Protestant martyrs to restore papal supremacy.

1559

Elizabeth I's Religious Settlement (The "Middle Way") Ref [2.2–2.3]

Elizabeth passes the Acts of Supremacy and Uniformity, naming herself Supreme Governor to balance Protestant doctrine with traditional ritual.

1570

Papal Bull Regnans in Excelsis Excommunicates Elizabeth Ref [2.4]

Pope Pius V declares Elizabeth a heretic and releases Catholic subjects from allegiance, sparking escalating assassination plots.

1587

Execution of Mary Queen of Scots & Singeing of Cadiz Ref [2.5, 3.2]

Walsingham traps Mary in the Babington Plot, leading to her execution at Fotheringhay. Drake raids Cadiz, delaying Spanish invasion plans.

Jul–Aug 1588

Defeat of the Spanish Armada at Calais & Gravelines Ref [3.3–3.5]

Philip II's invasion fleet is scattered by midnight fireships at Calais, out-gunned off Gravelines, and wrecked on Scottish rocks by Atlantic gales.

1629–1640

Charles I's Personal Rule ("Eleven Years' Tyranny") Ref [4.1]

Charles governs without Parliament, imposing Ship Money and Laud's high-church reforms, provoking armed Scottish Presbyterian rebellion.

1642–1648

Outbreak of Civil War & Cromwell's New Model Army Ref [4.2–4.3]

Charles storms the Commons to arrest five MPs, sparking open civil war. Parliament forms the disciplined New Model Army to crush Royalists.

30 Jan 1649

High Court Trial & Public Execution of King Charles I Ref [4.4]

Parliament puts the King on trial as a tyrant, traitor, and public enemy, beheading him at Whitehall and establishing a republican Commonwealth.

1688–1689

The Glorious Revolution & The 1689 Bill of Rights Ref [4.5, 5.5]

James II is ousted; William and Mary accept the Bill of Rights, establishing parliamentary supremacy, regular elections, and the rule of law.

ENQUIRY 01

PILLAR 1 • CORE HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

The Reformation & The Break with Rome (1517–1547)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION Why did Henry VIII break with Rome, and how was Royal Supremacy established?

[1.1] THE SPARK AT WITTENBERG (1517–1521)

How did Martin Luther's protest spark the Reformation across Europe?

In October 1517, German monk Martin Luther nailed 95 fiery arguments to the **Wittenberg church door**. Luther attacked corrupt friars selling an **indulgence**—a certificate promising that paying for forgiveness would free dead relatives from the agonies of **Purgatory**.

Printed copies spread across Europe, triggering the Protestant **Reformation**. When young King Henry VIII wrote a book defending Catholic sacraments against Luther, Pope Leo X rewarded him with the proud **Defender of the Faith title**.

[1.2] THE KING'S DYNASTIC CRISIS (1525–1527)

Why did the royal marriage become an urgent dynastic crisis?

By 1527, Henry faced an agonizing **dynastic** crisis. Catherine of Aragon was past forty and had borne only one living daughter, Princess Mary. Driven by a desperate need for a son to protect royal **succession**, Henry feared civil war if the Tudor dynasty collapsed without a male heir.

Having fallen deeply in love for Anne Boleyn, Henry cited a strict Bible warning on marriage from Leviticus, claiming his marriage to Catherine was cursed. He demanded an official papal **annulment** to marry again.

[1.3] THE ROMAN DEADLOCK (1527–1529)

Why did Pope Clement VII refuse Henry's annulment request?

Normally, popes readily granted royal annulments, but Pope Clement VII was trapped. In May 1527, Holy Roman Emperor Charles V—Catherine's nephew—led imperial troops that attacks Rome, ransacked the city, and left the Pope held prisoner in Castel Sant'Angelo.

Charles warned the **papacy** that ending Catherine's marriage would bring ruin. When Henry's chief minister Cardinal Wolsey opened a legatine court in London, Clement revoked the case, the church trial cancelled, and English **sovereignty** was defied, causing Wolsey's immediate arrest.

[1.4] CROMWELL'S PARLIAMENTARY SIEGE (1529–1533)

How did Thomas Cromwell use Parliament to pressure the Church?

A ruthless lawyer named Thomas Cromwell showed Henry how to bypass Rome. Cromwell used the Reformation Parliament to pass revolutionary **statute** laws. Henry cowed the English clergy by threatening church fines under ancient treason laws, forcing bishops into complete royal submission.

Cromwell escalated the siege by stopping taxes to Rome (annates) and passing the 1533 Act in Restraint of Appeals, banning appeals to the Pope. Archbishop Cranmer declared Henry's marriage void and crowned Anne Boleyn, sealing England's legal independence.

[1.5] ROYAL SUPREMACY & MONASTIC MELTDOWN (1534–1540)

How did the Act of Supremacy legally consolidate royal sovereignty?

In November 1534, Parliament passed the historic **Act of Supremacy**, formally breaking ties with Rome. The statute declared Henry the supreme head of the Church of England, holding absolute spiritual authority over English subjects.

Henry enforced loyalty through forced treason oaths; those refusing, including Sir Thomas More, were executed for **treason**. Cromwell then surveyed church wealth, dissolving over 800 Catholic monasteries between 1536 and 1540, selling monastic lands to gentry allies and permanently enriching the Crown.

ENQUIRY 02

PILLAR 1 • CORE HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

Elizabeth I & The Middle Way (1558–1588)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION How did Elizabeth I navigate religious divisions through the 1559 Via Media?

[2.1] A FRACTURED KINGDOM (1558–1559)

Why was England religiously fractured when Elizabeth became Queen?

In November 1558, twenty-five-year-old Elizabeth I inherited an acutely divided nation. Her Catholic half-sister Queen Mary I had launched fierce religious persecution, seeing almost three hundred Protestants burned at stake as heretics. Each brave Protestant **martyr** died holding English prayer books, inflaming fierce religious hatred across the country.

Simultaneously, the return of strict Puritans from European exile put pressure on the young queen. These militant Calvinists demanded that Elizabeth purge all Catholic ritual, Latin prayers, and bishops from the English Church.

[2.2] RESTORING CONTROL: SUPREME GOVERNOR (1559)

How did the Act of Supremacy restore royal control through compromise?

Elizabeth needed an enduring political **compromise** to avoid civil war. In early 1559, Parliament passed the Act of Supremacy. To soothe Catholics who believed only Christ or the Pope could lead the Church, Elizabeth adopted the clever title of **Supreme Governor** rather than Supreme Head.

The Act required strict loyalty oaths for priests and public officials. When all but one Marian Catholic bishop refused to take the oath, Elizabeth showed steel by sacking Catholic bishops and appointing moderate Protestants in their place.

[2.3] THE VIA MEDIA & THE PRAYER BOOK (1559)

How did the Act of Uniformity establish the 'Middle Way' (Via Media)?

Alongside supremacy, the 1559 Act of **Uniformity** established Elizabeth's famed **Via Media** (Middle Way). It introduced one shared prayer book for every parish, written in English. The communion service featured clever compromise wording that satisfied both Protestants and Catholics.

Attendance was strictly compulsory. Any Catholic **recusant** who refused to attend Sunday church services was punished with Sunday church fines (12d)—roughly a day's wages for a labourer. Elizabeth avoided probing private conscience, famously declaring she had no desire to make windows into men's souls.

[2.4] THE CATHOLIC STORM GATHERS (1568–1570)

How did Mary Queen of Scots and the Papal Bull spark Catholic plots?

Elizabeth's Middle Way soon faced violent Catholic resistance. In 1569, traditionalist Northern Earls rebel against royal authority, marching into Durham Cathedral, tearing down Protestant communion tables, and celebrating secret Catholic mass. Elizabeth swiftly crushed the rebellion, executing four hundred rebels.

In response, Pope Pius V issued the 1570 **papal bull** *Regnans in Excelsis*, ordering Elizabeth's **excommunication**. By declaring Elizabeth a heretic and usurper, the Pope orders Elizabeth deposed, freeing English Catholics from their allegiance and turning every Catholic subject into a suspected traitor.

[2.5] SPIES, CIPHERS & THE SCAFFOLD (1571–1588)

How did Walsingham's spy network lead to Mary's execution?

Mary Queen of Scots' arrival in England sparked deadly Catholic assassination plots. Elizabeth's spymaster Sir Francis Walsingham ran a sophisticated network of **espionage** to trap conspirators. In 1586, Anthony Babington plotted Elizabeth's murder, smuggling letters hidden in barrels of beer to Mary.

Walsingham intercepted the letters and had Mary's secret code broken by expert cryptographers. Confronted with Mary's treason, Parliament demanded blood. With deep reluctance, Elizabeth finally saw Mary's death warrant signed, and Mary Stuart was beheaded at Fotheringhay Castle in February 1587.

ENQUIRY 03

PILLAR 1 • CORE HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

The Spanish Armada & Naval Warfare (1588)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION Why was Philip II's Armada defeated, and how did naval strategy transform warfare?

[3.1] THE CATHOLIC CRUSADE (1585–1587)

What imperial and religious rivalries provoked Philip II's invasion?

By 1585, King Philip II of Spain launched a holy Catholic **crusade** to conquer Protestant England. Philip was infuriated by English help for Dutch rebels fighting Spanish rule in the Netherlands, and enraged by English **privateer** Sir Francis Drake stealing Spanish gold and raiding Caribbean treasure fleets.

When Mary Queen of Scots was beheaded in 1587, Philip secured papal blessings to depose Elizabeth. Philip assembled an invincible Armada to sail up the English Channel, ferry the Duke of Parma's veteran army from Flanders, and overthrow the Protestant Crown.

[3.2] SINGEING THE KING'S BEARD (APRIL 1587)

How did Drake's raid on Cadiz delay the Spanish invasion?

In April 1587, Francis Drake struck a daring pre-emptive blow, sailing directly into Cadiz harbour. In this raid, known as 'singeing the King of Spain's beard', Drake destroyed thirty Spanish warships and burned vast warehouses of seasoned barrel staves, devastating Spanish naval **logistics**.

Burning food barrels forced the Spanish to construct fresh casks from unseasoned green wood. Consequently, rotten water and bread contaminated supplies before the fleet even sailed. Drake's audacious raid caused the invasion fleet held back for a year, buying precious time for English coastal defenses.

[3.3] CHANNEL STANDOFF & GUN TACTICS (JULY 1588)

How did the English fleet harry the Armada up the English Channel?

On 29 July 1588, the Armada entered the English Channel under the Duke of Medina Sidonia. The Spanish sailed 130 ships in crescent line formation, designed to resist boarding attacks and protect slow transport vessels with lumbering floating castles.

Lord Howard and Drake counterattacked using faster race-built ships designed by John Hawkins. Rather than grappling, the nimble English ships delivered rapid naval **broadside** firepower, firing cannons from afar using long-range brass **culverin** guns that battered the Spanish formation while staying out of reach.

[3.4] MIDNIGHT HELLBURNERS AT CALAIS (7–8 AUGUST 1588)

How did English fireships at Calais shatter the Spanish formation?

On 7 August, the Armada anchored at Calais, waiting for Parma's delayed troops. Trapped in a vulnerable open **anchorage**, the Spanish were terrorized at midnight when English captains launched eight burning ghost ships coated in pitch and gunpowder directly toward their fleet.

Panicked Spanish captains shouted orders for cutting anchor ropes in panic to escape the blazing **fireship** threat. Scattering in the dark into the open North Sea, the Armada lost its defensive crescent formation forever, leaving individual vessels helpless against English gunfire.

[3.5] GRAVELINES & THE PROTESTANT WIND (AUGUST–SEPTEMBER 1588)

How did the Battle of Gravelines and severe storms destroy the fleet?

At the Battle of Gravelines, English warships closed in, blasting wooden hulls of each Spanish **galleon** at point-blank range. Blown northward into fierce North Sea gales, Medina Sidonia had no choice but to steer his battered fleet around Scotland and Ireland.

Furious Atlantic storms drove dozens of ships onto jagged Irish rocks, causing devastating shipwrecks. Only sixty-seven damaged vessels limped back to Spain. Elizabeth celebrated divine **providence**, striking a famous medal declaring: 'God blew and they were scattered', cementing England's naval and Protestant identity.

ENQUIRY 04

PILLAR 1 • CORE HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

The Civil War, Regicide & The Bill of Rights (1642–1689)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION Why did the collision over Divine Right lead to the trial and execution of Charles I?

[4.1] THE ELEVEN YEARS' TYRANNY (1629–1640)

Why did Charles I's 'Personal Rule' without Parliament cause outrage?

Believing in the absolute **Divine Right** of Kings, Charles I insisted monarchs answered only to God. When MPs challenged his religious policy and taxation in 1629, Charles dismissed Parliament and ruled for eleven years with no MPs, a period opponents branded the 'Eleven Years' Tyranny' or **Personal Rule**.

To raise funds without Parliament, Charles levied **Ship Money** on inland towns, an ancient naval tax traditionally charged only to coastal counties. In 1637, wealthy landowner John Hampden refuses to pay, sparking widespread tax boycotts across England.

[4.2] THE BREAKDOWN OF TRUST (1640–1642)

How did the breakdown of trust lead to armed civil conflict?

Scottish rebellion forced Charles to recall Parliament in 1640. Furious MPs dismantled royal courts and pursued the **impeachment** of Charles's closest ministers. Tensions exploded on 4 January 1642, when armed royal guards raid the Commons chamber as Charles attempted to arrest Five MPs for high treason.

Warned beforehand, the Five MPs escape by river boat into the protective shelter of the City of London. Humiliated and furious, Charles fled London. In August 1642, the King raises war flag at Nottingham, plunging England into brutal civil war.

[4.3] WAR & THE NEW MODEL ARMY (1642–1648)

How did the New Model Army defeat the King at the Battle of Naseby?

Early royalist victories exposed Parliament's weak regional militias. In 1645, Parliament created the revolutionary **New Model Army**: Britain's first professional national force of full-time paid redcoats, promoted purely on merit rather than noble birth, commanded by Sir Thomas Fairfax and Oliver Cromwell.

At the decisive Battle of Naseby in June 1645, Cromwell's cavalry charges smashed the King's flanks. Royalists routed and captured surrendered their artillery and private royal correspondence, completely destroying Charles's military hopes and sealing Parliamentary victory.

[4.4] THE TRIAL & EXECUTION OF CHARLES I (1648–1649)

Why did Pride's Purge and the High Court lead to regicide?

Charles refused to accept defeat, sparking a second civil war by plotting with Scottish allies. Determined to punish the 'man of blood', Colonel Pride used troops to purge Parliament; the Army kicks out moderate MPs, leaving a radical 'Rump'.

In January 1649, Charles was a king put on trial for treason before a High Court of Justice. Found guilty of **high treason** against his people, Charles was beheaded outside Whitehall on 30 January 1649, abolishing monarchy and establishing a revolutionary republic.

[4.5] THE GLORIOUS REVOLUTION & THE BILL OF RIGHTS (1660–1689)

How did the Glorious Revolution permanently limit royal power?

The 1660 Stuart **Restoration** brought back the Crown, but religious conflict reignited under Catholic King James II. In 1688, Protestant nobles invited Dutch Prince William of Orange to intervene. A Dutch army lands at Torbay, and James II flees the country to France in the Glorious Revolution.

Parliament offered the crown to William and Mary on strict conditions, enacting the 1689 **Bill of Rights**. Monarchy was permanently bound by the law: kings could neither cancel statutes nor raise taxes without parliamentary consent, cementing constitutional rule.

ENQUIRY 05

Crown, Church, or Parliament? (1517–1689)

KEY ENQUIRY QUESTION Which turning point decisively transformed the English state between 1517 and 1689?

[5.1] HENRY VIII & SOVEREIGN STATEHOOD (1517–1547)

How did Henry VIII reshape sovereign authority in the Reformation?

The Break with Rome transformed national authority. Under Henry VIII, the Pope lost all English power as the Crown established sovereign national independence. Crucially, Henry achieved this not by royal decree, but through **statute law** passed by the Reformation Parliament.

New laws made with MPs forged an unprecedented partnership between King and Parliament. Furthermore, vast monastery lands given away or sold to local gentry bound England's landowning classes to royal supremacy, laying the foundations of modern English parliamentary **sovereignty**.

[5.2] THE ELIZABETHAN PROTESTANT IDENTITY (1558–1603)

How did the Elizabethan settlement forge a Protestant national state?

Elizabeth I anchored national unity through pragmatic statecraft. Her 1559 Elizabethan Religious Settlement provided a compromise for both sides, creating a Protestant national church with moderate ceremonies that allowed broad outward **conformity** without religious inquisitions.

She enforced order through modest fines for missing church on Sundays to penalize recusants. When Spain invaded in 1588, England was united by Armada victory, forging a lasting patriotic myth that God favoured Protestant England and strengthening parliamentary support for the Crown.

[5.3] THE STUART RUPTURE: DIVINE RIGHT (1603–1640)

Why did Stuart claims of Divine Right provoke constitutional crisis?

The Stuart accession shattered Tudor harmony. James I and Charles I embraced **absolutism**, insisting through Divine Right that kings claim only God rules them, free from parliamentary consent. Charles ruled eleven years without MPs, extracting illegal taxes without votes through Ship Money.

This tyranny collapsed when Scots rebel against English rules and prayer books. Bankrupted by military resistance, Charles was forced to recall MPs in 1640, triggering an ideological showdown between absolute royal power and parliamentary privilege.

[5.4] THE SHOCK OF REGICIDE & REPUBLIC (1642–1649)

Why was the trial and execution of Charles I a radical turning point?

The Civil War transformed English constitutional history. Parliament's citizen army beat the King at Naseby, ending royal hopes of military victory. Following Charles's repeated intrigues, Pride's Purge cleared dissenters from Parliament, abolishing the House of Lords and monarchy to establish a republican **Commonwealth**.

Beheading Charles I in 1649 set a revolutionary **precedent**: an anointed monarch was held to the law. A ruler who broke his constitutional trust with the people could be tried and executed for treason.

[5.5] THE 1689 BILL OF RIGHTS: PARLIAMENTARY SUPREMACY (1689)

How did the 1689 Bill of Rights finalize Parliamentary Supremacy?

The 1688 Glorious Revolution and 1689 Bill of Rights established permanent **constitutional monarchy** across the realm. Parliament drafted a binding statutory contract with new rulers William III and Mary II, legally ending centuries of royal claims to absolute divine power.

The statute confirmed that the King cannot cancel laws without Parliament, prohibited royal taxes without MP votes, and removed the Crown's royal **veto** over parliamentary statutes. Sovereignty had shifted decisively from the personal will of the monarch to the supreme authority of the King-in-Parliament.

MASTER DISCIPLINARY RETRIEVAL ENGINE

MASTER KNOWLEDGE RETRIEVAL QUIZ

Standard Recall Protocol: 25 core retrieval questions testing factual mastery across all five enquiries. Use for low-stakes weekly partner testing, silent memory flash-checks, or end-of-unit homework retrieval. (Answers verified in textbook narrative; zero answers printed.)

ENQUIRY 1: THE REFORMATION & THE BREAK WITH ROME

Page 3 • Ref [1.1]–[1.5]

1. In what year did Martin Luther nail his 95 Theses in Wittenberg?
2. What corrupt Catholic certificates did Martin Luther attack for promising forgiveness for money?
3. What title was Henry VIII awarded by the Pope in 1521 for defending the Catholic sacraments?
4. Which Spanish wife failed to give Henry VIII a surviving male heir, triggering his "Great Matter"?
5. What 1534 law declared Henry VIII to be the Supreme Head of the Church of England?

ENQUIRY 2: ELIZABETH I & THE MIDDLE WAY

Page 4 • Ref [2.1]–[2.5]

1. How many Protestant martyrs were burned at the stake during the reign of Queen Mary I?
2. What title did Elizabeth I choose in 1559 instead of "Supreme Head" to compromise with Catholics?
3. What was Elizabeth's religious compromise called that balanced Protestant doctrine with traditional ceremonies?
4. What were Catholics called who refused to attend the compulsory Sunday Church of England services?
5. In what year did Pope Pius V issue the Papal Bull excommunicating Elizabeth and calling for her overthrow?

ENQUIRY 3: THE SPANISH ARMADA

Page 5 • Ref [3.1]–[3.5]

1. Which Catholic King of Spain launched the Armada in 1588 to invade England?
2. What harbour raid in 1587 did Francis Drake call "singeing the King of Spain's beard"?
3. What defensive crescent-shaped formation did the 130 ships of the Armada sail in up the English Channel?
4. What terrifying weapon did Drake launch at midnight against the anchored Spanish fleet off Calais?
5. What natural event wrecked dozens of Spanish galleons off the coasts of Scotland and Ireland?

ENQUIRY 4: CIVIL WAR, REGICIDE & THE BILL OF RIGHTS

Page 6 • Ref [4.1]–[4.5]

1. What belief held that kings were appointed by God and could not be questioned by Parliament?
2. What illegal coastal tax did Charles I force inland towns to pay during his 11 Years' Tyranny?
3. What was Oliver Cromwell's professional, disciplined Parliamentary army called?
4. On what date was King Charles I publicly beheaded outside the Banqueting House in Whitehall?
5. What famous constitutional document did William and Mary sign in 1689 to make Parliament supreme?

ENQUIRY 5: SYNOPTIC CHANGE & CONTINUITY (1517–1689)

Page 7 • Ref [5.1]–[5.5]

1. In 1517, to which foreign religious leader did the King and Church of England answer?
2. By 1689, which institution had the legal authority to approve taxes and create laws in Britain?
3. What radical group of poor peasants attempted to farm common land for all people on St George's Hill in 1649?
4. Did the legal rights and everyday lives of poor agricultural labourers and women change significantly between 1517 and 1689?
5. What 1689 law allowed non-conformist Protestants to worship freely, while still keeping restrictions on Catholics?

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